ULFA. Connectivity over surface routes was given a quantum jump by transit facility from Bangladesh to Nepal and Bhutan, and India was given access to the ports of Chittagong and Mongla. All these measures will contribute to the economic upliftment of the people of this region. A few years ago, this kind of cooperation, though highly desirable, was unimaginable. I had written in *The Telegraph* over four years ago of the benefits that would accrue to Bangladesh and the northeastern states of India by exploiting the Brahmaputra as a waterway from Kolkata to Dibrugarh with ports of call enroute in Bangladesh and Assam. Today, it is very satisfying to see some of these pathbreaking initiatives being progressed, and both nations should maintain this momentum in their national interest. However, keeping the extremists at bay would be fundamental for these initiatives to succeed.

The relationship between Sri Lanka and India had become very complex because of the historical, cultural and traditional affinity of the Tamil people of both countries. In the same breath, the close bonds and kinship between our people because of Buddhism and Tamil ethnicity make for an extremely vibrant relationship. For over two decades, Sri Lanka had been ravaged by the insurgency spawned by the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE). Unfortunately, because of the Tamil sensitivities and the LTTE, our government's foreign policy had to be crafted treading on a fine line. This posed an enormous challenge to our mandarins in the south block. To their credit they were able to avoid the pitfalls and managed to conduct the relationship adroitly. With the end of hostilities in Sri Lanka, we have begun to play an extremely useful and positive role in the reconstruction of the war-ravaged northern and eastern regions of Sri Lanka, which bore the brunt during the conflict. We must leave no doubt that we stand for a united, peaceful and progressive Sri Lanka. Things appear to be looking up already with India being the largest trade partner of Sri Lanka and the second largest investor.